You Belong in My Classroom

Recently I felt to write an essay on safety, belonging, pride flags, and creating an environment in which all can thrive. That essay was published in Public Square Magazine, and now appears here with minor revisions based on feedback from the public and from dear friends.

I am a faculty member of a school sponsored by The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. We support its doctrines and promote its values. We believe that man-woman marriage is an essential part of fulfilling God's plan for us and we believe in being chaste before and after marriage.

On Belonging

Let me begin by addressing my students. I want to get to the most important thing first. Human beings need to belong like they need air or water. It is fundamental. You *belong* in my classroom.

- If you are a closeted gay student, you belong in my classroom.
- If you are unsure whether the Church is true, you belong in my classroom.
- If you've gone through--or are going through--abuse, you belong in my classroom.
- If you're not sure about your gender, you belong in my classroom.
- If you think the world is unjust, you belong in my classroom.
- If you're LGBT+ and out and trying to navigate what that means for you at a CES school, you belong in my classroom.
- If you've been through something awful and it's just hard to trust in general, you belong in my classroom.
- If you are battling mental illness, you belong in my classroom.
- If you're a boring kid from a boring town with a boring life, except for some things you don't want to talk about, you can talk about them with me or not. Either way, you belong in my classroom.

No matter who you are, I want you here, and I aim to help you feel that you belong. I want to build a community that welcomes and supports you—a safe community. I also want you to find a community that gives you that sense of profound belonging. Belonging is deep: it is being a part of a community that loves you, and allows you to thrive; a community of friends, norms, expectations, and culture that brings structure, richness, and joy to life.

On Safety

In my original essay, I suggested that “you were safe in my classroom.” A friend pointed out that I cannot make that call: only you can decide what “safe” means, and whether I qualify. I hope I do, but all I can commit to is trying to make that kind of environment for you and respecting your choice if this isn’t for you. As such, let me explain what I think safe means, and what I intend to do to build safety in my classroom for you.

- Safe begins with, but is far more than, physical safety.

- Safe means that slurs, derogatory comments, or hurtful responses will be addressed directly and if appropriate, publicly. When asked, students often report that these comments are the most significant factor in making them unsafe. I will not tolerate such.

- Safe also means that I won’t refer you to student discipline or the honor code for things like wrestling with your testimony, your experience of gender, or your orientation *because none of those things are infractions in any meaningful sense.*

- Safe means that you are not in any way suspect for identifying as LGBT+ in terms of honesty, integrity, or worthiness.

- Safe means that I will listen to your experience and do what I am able if you tell me that you have been made to feel unsafe.

- Safe means that I will follow the most up-to-date guidance from the Church and will do my best to avoid outdated or incorrect teachings about sexuality in my class. I will also do my best to correct students, when necessary, and point them to reliable resources on the topic.

- Safe means that if you are going through an abusive situation, you can speak to me in privacy and that I will do my best to listen and get you resources. (Note: I’m not an expert in this. I’ll *strongly* encourage you to speak with one.)

- Safe means that if there are academic or honor code concerns, I will do everything I can to help you navigate a difficult situation with integrity and compassion.

- Safe means that I will push you academically and spiritually out of my belief in your capacity.

- Safe also means that I will do as much as I can to help a straight student or a gay student navigate those tricky waters as I can and will be aware of how I might be treating different students differently based on how they identify.

And now, let me clarify what “safe” does not mean.

- Safe does not mean neutral. I am fully on the side of the restored gospel. If you are in my class, you will hear me preach the restoration, particularly the doctrine of the family, of which I have a strong personal testimony that comes from academic, spiritual, and personal experience.

- Safe does not mean that I will avoid tricky topics around you, nor that I'll always get them right.

- Safe does not mean that your ideas are safe. The purpose of the academy is to promote good ideas, but also to eliminate bad ones. The people who espouse anarcho-capitalism and utopian-marxism are welcome in my class, and the ideas they hold should be subject to repeated, deliberate fire—or you deserve your money back. You are safe with me. Your ideas are not. I intend to push on them.

- Safe does not mean that you won't get feedback. My primary job is to give you skills and reasoning abilities that will make you a better thinker, a better citizen, and a better professional. Growth means growing pains. Do not mistake feedback as uncaring. It is fundamental to your development and is part of what you are paying for.

- Safe does not imply low expectations. I intend to push you. I do not apologize for it.

- Safe does not mean that I won't sometimes offer a deliberate, direct, and well-motivated rebuke if warranted.

- Safe does not mean that I will always agree with you. Note, however, that I care infinitely more about improving the quality of your thinking than making you agree with me.

- Safe does not mean that I will let you come to class out of dress code, unprepared, or in any way that could harm the learning environment. In fact, you can be assured that I will be swift to defend the learning environment. I will not apologize for asking you to live up to your commitments. I care enough about you to ask you to expect that you live a life of integrity: that you make commitments carefully and keep them resolutely.

- Safe does not mean that I'll turn a blind eye to the breaking of your commitments and covenants. I speak particularly, here, of the honor code. Safe means that if you've made a mistake, my first goal is your long-term welfare: to help you figure out how to make peace with things and move productively forward.

- Safe does not mean that I will trade this unique mission of the university for the personal validation of a student—no matter how dearly I may love them. This place is beautiful—and even sacred—precisely because we are a community of saints, striving disciples who are imperfectly aiming for full commitment to Jesus Christ. We are defined, here, by our discipleship to Him first. While other elements of your identity are valid and important, it is this shared identity that forms a community of striving saints.

On Danger

Safe doesn't mean that I'll always get things right. I'll need grace sometimes. I commit to trying. If I do make a mistake, I hope you'll give me a bit of grace—and remember your own strength—until I can rectify things quickly and earnestly.

And yet, I need to discuss a troubling aspect of the way we are using the word “safe.”

A friend points out the implicit danger of using the word with care: consider what safe implies about those who are not? Are they unsafe? Even dangerous? There is a frightening logical end to this discussion that deserves its own article, for another time. For now, however, I will simply challenge the notion that those who have deep differences with me on theology are in any way unsafe—and call for us to notice the problematic nature of such a narrative.

On a related note, I am also concerned that our dialogue on these issues is too focused on powerless oppression rather than resilient empowerment. I pray for a world in which we will not need thick skin. I wish that I could prevent every injustice. In the face of reality, however, I advocate for a narrative of strength and empowerment rather than one of powerlessness and victimhood. I hope that it will be the narrative of consecration and discipleship—that my LGBT+ students find the same joy and meaning as I do from the gospel. In any event, I hope that they find a narrative of strength, thriving, agency, and resilience, rather than one of despair.

To my students, then, I will do everything I can to help you belong. To help you—in the ways I’ve outlined, at least—to be safe.

On Symbols

And now, I write for myself—in reflection, mostly—but hoping that I might say something that is of use for my fellow faculty.

When I sat down to write this article, I wanted to speak to even the most orthodox faculty and help them see that the list above is something that they can do without compromising their commitments to the gospel in the least part. In fact, I believe that it is our obligation to do all in our power to welcome all as Jesus would—and while my list is certainly imperfect, the general thrust strikes me as the right one. In the venn diagram of gay rights and gospel fidelity, anything in the union between the two—anything that helps students be more welcome, to belong, and to thrive on this campus, that does not conflict with our theology around the family is something that we ought to engage with seriously.

In the same way, I’d like to share with my faculty friends about another topic: I have made a personal decision not to display pride flags, and I’d like to explain a bit about why.

I was talking to a colleague recently, and I said “I have considered putting up a pride flag—to communicate all the love, inclusion, and kindness that it entails. Unfortunately, it also communicates something else: a set of morals and values that run contrary to the restored gospel. How can I signal that students are welcome without also signaling something I do not believe in?”

My wise colleague chewed on that thought a bit. Then she said, “If we’re truly Christians, shouldn’t it go without saying that they are welcome and safe?”

She's right. If I need a flag to let students know that they are safe, I'm doing something wrong—and I'm probably not living up to my role as a disciple of Jesus.

I told my friend that I wanted to do two things: make everyone welcome and stand firmly behind the restored truths that I believe in. One of us—I can't remember who—sketched a little image of the Christus, with the words underneath that say "I am a disciple of Jesus Christ. I will welcome all, and I will stand for truth."

That has become my little symbol. A very countercultural one, I would wager.

Is that enough? Perhaps not. If there are faculty who bully, harass, or treat students in an unkind way, or who would use their faith as a pretext for unkindness, I urge hard conversations with those faculty, by administrators, in a context of professional consequences. If there are those who would mask bigotry with the symbol of Jesus, they will have to answer to Him for it later, and should have to answer to the university for it now.

I take a hard line on this, on the condition that we are careful to judge: while swift correction may be in order, campus needs to be a place that has high expectations and also high grace for earnest mistakes. Outdated statements—as much as we should correct them—are not bullying. Honest mistakes are not "unsafe."

And most especially, testifying of the doctrine of the family is not "dangerous."

To the contrary, it is the doctrine on the family that—I believe—the world needs now more than ever.

On Division

It is my personal conviction that strong families are the basis for rich lives and thriving nations. I come from a background in public education in which I have seen the impact of families on student outcomes—both in their academic lives, and in the full path of their life. I have yet to find a teacher who believes that the problem in education is *too many* strong families, teaching clear morals and the value of education to their children. I do not know of any teacher who believes that student behavior is getting *better* over time, or that the flood of behavioral concerns and mental illnesses are a mere statistical spike.

To the contrary, my teacher friends plainly say what politicians dare not: that our problems have their roots in parenting and family. I mourn the children whom I have known who have suffered abuse and neglect, who regularly breathe in the smoggy societal pollution of violence, smut, and confusion, and who have relied upon adults in their lives who have let them down. I increasingly worry about the messages that children are being sent about sexuality, gender roles, and gender itself—and how that confusion will affect my own children when they come of age.

I work with future teachers, and my message is resolute: the research literature is clear that teachers can make an impact in even these circumstances—and yet, I am tired of preaching resilience and healing to those who should not have to be healing to begin with. I fear that we

are not living up to the obligations of caring for our little ones, and that we risk the wrath of a loving-but-ultimately-just God.

Again, it has been my experience that the church's doctrine on the family is inspired, and precisely what this world needs more of. Similarly, I have strong feelings about the inspired mission and unique nature of CES schools—especially in the face of a higher education industry that is in desperate need of reform.

As such, I was thrilled to hear Elder Holland's recent remarks that touched on both topics.

As he spoke, I was struck by his discussion of symbols that divide. My plain reading of the text was that he may have been asking Church-sponsored school employees to take down pride paraphernalia. As a friend put it, I cannot be culturally naïve enough to suggest that pride symbols only suggest acceptance—they also denote a different interpretation of the law of chastity than the one to which I hold. Displaying a pride flag does more than signal love. It signals *group allegiance* and communicates something about how I feel about our teachings.

At the same time, I fear that other symbols might begin to appear—symbols of anger and hatred, or divisiveness. Even symbols of what I will call "chip-on-my-shoulder-discipleship," or "in-your-face" testimony-bearing on very specific, very culturally explosive topics—topics that seem to be more relevant to politics and culture wars than defending the faith, or deepening discipleship.

My decision is to avoid such in favor of symbols that focus me on Jesus, my discipleship, my integrity, and my compassion.

I won't pretend to interpret an apostle's remarks for anyone other than me. I only seek to apply them personally—but in my view, he has asked me to distance myself from such. Why? What is there to learn from this?

In part, it should be redundancy. If I'm a disciple, my students should be safe from slurs, physical attacks, bullying, or any other form of unkindness—full stop. The safety, love, and belonging that the pride flag communicates should be utterly redundant, if I'm serious about being a Christian.

It's more than mere redundancy, however. We must pursue unity as a prophetic imperative. Unity comes from righteousness, not the other way around—and tribal signals of any kind detract from that unity more than they shore it up.

Consider the insidious long-term effect: if a faithful Muslim teacher—who holds that homosexuality is sin—does not put up a pride flag, are they "safe?" If an Evangelical Christian or Orthodox Jew does not put up a pride flag, should an LGBT+ student assume that they are not "safe"—or worse, that they are in fact "dangerous?"

Should I view those who do not believe in God as members of another tribe—and more importantly, of an opposing one? Should I treat my Catholic friends as suspect because they do not affirm that my baptism is valid?

Of course not. These people are safe (or not) depending on how they treat me, not on whether we agree on theology or philosophy.

When I was a middle school teacher, I thought long and hard about putting up a pride flag. I taught eighth graders, and frankly, I don't think they care much about just how heteronormative my theology is. They want to know if I'll treat them kindly, and protect their dignity. A pride symbol, in that instance, communicates a sense of safety. I respect that in some contexts the pride flag may be warranted, even if I have chosen not to. I am not wise enough to judge the hearts of others on this issue.

A church-sponsored university seems to me a different matter, however. Here, pride imagery predisposes us to assume that anyone not loudly proclaiming their group affiliation is unsafe—and perhaps even one of the bad guys. Those with no pride flag come to suspect those with one of disparaging and undermining Church *teachings* behind closed doors. Likewise, those with one may come to suspect those who don't of disparaging and undermining LGBT *people* behind closed doors. These mutual suspicions grow, and each side feels attacked by the other. The pride flag quickly becomes less about acceptance, and more about planting one's flag in the trenches of the culture war.

When Elder Holland called these symbols divisive, surely this was part of what he meant: that some imagery causes us to factionalize and suspect each other, rather than to come to unity.

And I reiterate: if a symbol of Jesus is not redundant as a symbol of safety, I believe it is time to have hard conversations with any in the university community who are not willing to walk the path of discipleship in truly welcoming all.

On Dichotomies, False and True

To another issue.

A false choice (otherwise called a false dichotomy) is when you are made to choose between two options when more exist. I tell my son that he can go to bed now, or in five minutes, for example. False dichotomies are often used as a way to manipulate the situation—as I will admit to doing with my children's bedtime.

There is a false dichotomy that Elder Holland addressed directly.

Some have suggested that in order to be loving, we must give up our beliefs regarding the family. They argue that our beliefs are inherently harmful and damaging to our LGBTQ friends, and that there we must choose a side: fidelity to doctrine, or kindness to friends.

I suspect that some of the anger directed at Elder Holland was precisely because he so directly rejected this false choice. Perhaps some were angry because they were being asked to love others, and perhaps some became angry because they were being asked to stand for Church doctrine on the family; but some seemed to me most threatened by the notion that defending Church doctrine and including others are not fundamentally at odds, and in fact, are both parts of our walk as disciples. This position strikes at the very heart of the "agree-with-me-or-you-don't-love-me" crowd.

We are required to be both faithful and welcoming.

Let me reiterate: Elder Holland explained that Jesus loved everyone, and never once did he say "because I love you, you can skip the commandments." I'm arguing that some people were angry precisely because he rejected the strategy of false choice in favor of acknowledging that *Christians must both believe in Christian doctrine and also treat others as Christians do.* Again, for those who have been using the strategy of "agree-or-you-don't-really-love-me" that was damning indeed.

I stand, firmly, behind the idea that it is my obligation to be loving and inclusive and stand unapologetically for the doctrine of the family.

On Loyalty

Now, do you have to listen to Elder Holland? I do not know. I know that I do. I have made a promise to sustain him, and have prayed for myself to know that he is called of God. If I were to treat lightly his sayings, I would stand condemned before God.

And you? Surely members of the Church have some latitude here, and I would insist that this issue not become another litmus test of loyalty. We must provide room for those who are sincerely asking, seeking, and knocking—room for them, and time too. But that latitude doesn't extend infinitely—nor does it extend to activism.

Elder David A. Bednar frequently mentions the difference between members of the community who are here in order to attempt to "change the university" rather than "allowing themselves to be changed by the university." If you are in my class to allow the experience to change you, you will have a rich, meaningful, hopefully life-changing experience. Similarly, I believe that any on the university campus—faculty, employee, or student—who is here to learn of Jesus and become His disciple should be given time and space to wrestle with difficult issues like this one.

At a church-sponsored university, I take seriously the obligation to listen to prophets. I think we all should, all the time, but it seems particularly important here.

On Covenants and Pluralism

What about those who are at the university to change the institution? I expect you will experience frustration and turmoil. I do not believe it is disloyal to still be working on issues of

testimony or theology—we all are. I do believe it to be disloyal to be here to remake the university after your own image.

What is the answer, then?

My friend Marian Edmonds-Allen recently taught me about a concept called "covenantal pluralism." It is an ancient and complex concept, and I do not pretend to have mastered it—however, I believe it is a key to healing the faith/LGBT divide.

This is not mere pluralism—this goes deeper than just "you do you" or "live and let live." Covenental pluralism is recognizing that there is something sacred and important about protecting and defending the rights of others to worship according to the dictates of their own conscience, and to worship how, where, or what they may. It is seeing my Catholic friend walking to mass and being willing to defend his right to do so—not out of hopeful reciprocity, but out of the holiness of his own walk. It is seeing a gay friend and believing that she is deserving of dignity, even if we have core disagreements about sexuality. It is realizing that church-sponsored schools aim to create a sacred place for disciples to gather who prioritize obedience to the commandments, and that their beliefs about sexuality and the family are a part of their right to believe as they choose—to worship "how, where, or what they may."

And it is my desire to ensure that my LGBT friends know that I will defend their rights and dignity in any way I can, even while I hold to my theology dearly, because I actually believe it.

And I do. I believe God has revealed a way to be happy, and all who will can choose to live by it—and yes, that includes laws regarding sexuality. I am wise enough to realize how much we have yet to receive at His hands, and yet I think for myself we would do well to listen for what God is already telling us. That is a dichotomy, of sorts: a sword that is quick and powerful, so to speak. We can choose to align with what we believe, or we can continue to be a house divided. It seems to me long overdue that we come to terms with our own doctrine and move forward—both because I believe in the doctrine, but also for the psychological benefit of those who have been repeatedly yanked back-and-forth between those advocating change (and promising that it was right around the corner) and the unchanging doctrine of the Church on this issue.

Covenental pluralism means recognizing that we want to do something unique, sacred, and special here: to build a community of disciples who are committing their whole lives to the teachings of Jesus. It means going to BYU out of a commitment to discipleship, not low tuition or strong academics or to please a parent. It means coming here because this is a special place, and I want to be part of something special.

And it means that I get to be okay with people for whom this might not be the place they would choose to go—and loving them the fiercer for it. It means doing all in my power to defend and protect the dignity of my dear LGBT friends, even as I hold to the doctrines that I believe in profoundly. It means hearing them when they hurt, and recognizing their dignity as partially my responsibility.

In closing, to my students, one more thing. I believe you are a child of God. You are a being of divine parentage, born with a destiny of glory. I will only ever affirm your true identity, which is a beloved child of Heavenly Parents, and a disciple of Christ. I will always urge you to be true to that identity, and let it predominate in your life.

There are two things that I will hold to—treating all as Christ would and standing unapologetically for Church doctrine without “even a hint of advocacy” for things that do not conform to gospel standards. I will do it imperfectly, but I will give it my best shot. I will be all in. I will give my imperfect hand, and my full heart to this cause.

And this will be my symbol:

I am a disciple of Jesus Christ. I will welcome all. And I will stand for truth.